the impossibility of getting Tendulkar and Dravid at the best of times, and dream of sleep.

We walk out of the dressing room, through the painful pinging and clattering of the Lord's Long Room, every sound now making an incision into my skull, through the clapping and the hollering of the members, and out into the light. As I walk on to the field, I experience that same transformation that playing cricket tends to do to me. Within seconds, just in the walk between the rope and taking the ball to start the morning's play, I forget about the night before. My body does too. I suddenly feel sharp and focused. It's as if the world outside the boundary is a different one entirely, and I inhabit a new skin when I get on to play.

We toil for a second, trying and failing to provoke VVS Laxman and a majestically in-form Rahul Dravid, who has scored a hundred in the first innings, into a mistake. I am working though, my brain running through a hundred different plans, relieved for a second from the tiredness, latching on to the task at hand. At 94-1, I have been working on a plan to get Dravid into the habit of playing. Every ball has been at his stumps, making him feel that every ball I bowl at him needs to be answered with a shot. I then come from wider on the crease, creating an angle, the one that gives a slight illusion, and hang the ball outside off stump. He does what I am praying he will do: hangs his bat out there, almost accidentally, out of habit. There is the sound of a click, like the sound of the clock ticking through the night, and Matt Prior takes the catch.

Laxman, just past fifty, is then tempted into a pull shot off my bowling. Tendulkar is at the crease – in England searching for his hundredth hundred. His every innings this summer is suddenly loaded with the heavy sub-plot of the ground wondering whether they are witnessing history, whether they are all some part of it. Even England fans, you sense, really want to be there when he does. I'm too tired for any of that, I just want him gone. As he's starting to tick, at the crease for nearly an hour and a half, I find the ball I am looking for. It's a hooping inswinger, freezing Sachin in a defensive shot that he can't undo, angling in and hitting his front pad. It's out. Later in the day, I get one to angle back into the left-hander and the last Indian hope of drawing the game, Suresh Raina. The adrenaline as I take the wicket is like an alien life force. I don't know where it's come from or how it has been fizzed out of my system, but it has, and we've won. As I watch them mark